

Stavich Bike Trail to reopen soon

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STRUTHERS — An important connection between Ohio and Pennsylvania has been broken for nearly a year, but that is expected to change soon.

The Stavich Bike Trail, a 10.5-mile ribbon of pavement that begins in Struthers off state Route 289 and ends on Covert Road near New Castle, Pa., should be open again by the end of the year.

Major hazards have been fixed since the Pennsylvania part of the trail was closed in December, said Doniele Andrus, a shared greenways and environmental planner who works for Lawrence and Beaver counties of Pennsylvania.

There were no dangerous spots along the three miles of the trail in Ohio.

Lawrence County used \$267,200 in federal funds distributed through the Pennsylvania Department of Environmental Protection to repair three bridges along the trail and a major washout just outside Lowellville, Andrus said last week.

She said 32 culverts were replaced and banks were stabilized in drainage improvements.

Now, the county is awaiting \$224,000 from the Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources to repave the trail and put up new signs, she said. It should arrive any day — it was expected Sept. 15, she said.

Meanwhile, people are using the trail. While they're on the seven miles of it that belong to Lawrence County, they need to know they're using it at their own risk, Andrus said.

People need to stay off the trail when the paving starts, which could be at any time, she said.

For bicyclists such as John McCormick, a member of the Youngstown-area bicycle club Out-Spokin' Wheelmen, the trail is a connection to sleepy little towns such as Lowellville, where he and other Wheelmen like to stop at a weekly car show, and to the hills and woods of Lawrence County.

Runners and roller-bladers use it too, said McCormick, who began cycling 15 years ago to improve his health and can bike the trail in less than an hour on his 20-year-old 12-speed.

"Wind is sometimes a factor," he said last week as he pointed out some of the trail's scenery. "You could do the trail in 40 minutes, but it could take you an hour to come back."

McCormick was on foot Tuesday morning as he made his way toward one of the new bridges, a wooden one over Coffee Run about four miles from the start of the trail.

"If you come here in June or July, there are mulberries," he said while pointing out the trees, though fall is evident along the trail now. Nearby, a small walnut tree was loaded down with fat, green nuts.

The trail follows the Mahoning River and railroad tracks, having once been a rail bed itself before becoming an electric trolley line in 1889. Campbell philanthropist John Stavich and his brothers, Andy and

George, donated \$200,000 to finish the trail, which was started in the 1970s. It was dedicated in 1983, according to Vindicator files.

Humans aren't the only creatures you'll see along the trail.

"I've seen a lot of deer," said McCormick. A mother raccoon and four of her half-grown babies crossed in front of him as he walked toward a beaver pond about eight miles from the trail's head in Struthers.

Ducks cut paths there through a green layer of duckweed on the water, and it isn't unusual to see geese and blue herons, McCormick said.

McCormick said he likes the Stavich trail mainly because it's conveniently close to his home.

It's hilly and bumpy in spots, he said, and sometimes the pavement is cracked and broken, though that will no longer be an issue.

He said the trail might be a little strenuous for a beginner, though people who've been riding for at least a year won't find it as much of a challenge.

Notably missing on the trail is the litter that often spoils areas used by humans — the crumpled tin cans, candy wrappers and cigarette butts.

"Bikers like the idea of 'leave no trace,'" McCormick said.

Though the summer is over, cycling doesn't have to be, McCormick said.

Fall is a great time to ride because it's cooler, and bikers tend to be in top shape by then, he said.

The Wheelmen ride nearly every day of the week, and they ride in winter, he said.

Their Web site, www.outspokenwheelmen.com, has more information.

<http://www.vindy.com/news/2009/sep/27/stavich-bike-trail-to-reopen-soon/>